

Xiaomi wants to capture the real world

Memories don't need AI to be generated

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In a market drunk on AI, one of India's biggest smartphone brands is doubling down on physics. I sat down with Sandeep Singh Arora, Chief Business Officer and Anuj Sharma, Chief Marketing Officer at Xiaomi India, on the sidelines of the Xiaomi 17 series launch, to talk about optical engineering, the harsh economic realities of buying a flagship today and why your next smartphone purchase might just force you to choose between AI and reality.

A photograph?

As someone who's perpetually on the internet, it is becoming increasingly difficult to discern whether a picture or a video is real or AI-generated. Xiaomi is leaning heavily into its deep partnership with Leica and the 17 Ultra.

"Everyone else is doing this [heavy digital processing], right? I think it's a very different philosophy," says Anuj Sharma. "What is a photograph? A photograph is a capture of time for your memory. It always should mean something. If it's been created by AI, it wasn't exactly that moment of time."

He pushes the point further. "AI creation for images is great for WhatsApp forwards. It's probably great for a profile pic. But is it really a memory if you're creating it?"

Arora backs it up saying, "Everybody is going one way. They're trying to do digital processing, more and more. There was a YouTuber talking about how a night picture will have multiple shots pieced together. But it'll lose the realism. It'll lose the details." He pauses. "We are going down a different path."



Sandeep Singh Arora
CBO, Xiaomi India

range by expanding full-well capacity. The result is a single frame that can simultaneously hold blinding highlights and deep shadows without sacrificing either. Internally, Sharma tells me, the project had a code name: Night God. "In daylight, it does not clip at the



Anuj Sharma
CMO, Xiaomi India

highest end," Anuj Sharma explains. "And in the same single frame, it is able to take both extremely bright and dark elements. And retains the information which nobody else can do."

"If you're in a club," he says, "you've got harsh lighting coming in. But you're not there to take the club's photograph. You're there to take your friend's photo. So how do you capture your friend and that entire scene?"

Because what everybody else is doing, broadly, is AI compositing by stitching multiple exposures, filling in gaps algorithmically, constructing

a photo, not capturing one. Sometimes it's effective, sometimes it's spectacular, but Xiaomi's position is that it's not photography.

With LOFIC, the dynamic range number that Sharma quotes is worth stopping at: 108 dB in daylight and 90 dB at night. He draws a comparison to the human eye which operates at roughly 100 dB and frames the gap that's now been closed.

1-inch sensor

The Xiaomi 17 Ultra carries the company's first 1-inch-type LOFIC sensor. LOFIC stands for Lateral Overflow Integration Capacitor, if you want the full mouthful. It is imaging engineering that dramatically increases a sensor's dynamic

The Leica legacy

That different path involves what might be the most quietly impressive spec to come out of the Xiaomi-Leica partnership, now in its fourth year: a 200MP telephoto with a mechanical optical zoom range of 75mm to 100mm.

"Last year we had four lenses," Sharma says. "This year we have only three. So it must have been cheaper?" He laughs before answering his own rhetorical question. "But no."

The telephoto module uses a high-resolution sensor with a variable focal system, allowing movement in portrait focal lengths to maintain detail. **d**

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